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FROM THE FIELD · RMF / ATO

A C3PAO Validates the Evidence Problem Behind Vault-Codex

A CMMC assessor's letter of support confirms the documentation and evidence-management problem is real - and where MacTech Vault-Codex fits.

BY **MAXINE** READING TIME · 7 MIN RMF · CUI · CMMC

A CMMC Third Party Assessment Organization does not often put a sentence like this in writing on a company's behalf: "The underlying problem is real and relevant." Axiotrop LLC did, in a letter of support dated June 23, 2026, backing a Small Business Innovation Research proposal MacTech Solutions filed with the Defense Logistics Agency under topic DLA26BZ02-NV006.

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RMF

"The underlying problem is real and relevant."

Axiotrop is a C3PAO, one of the organizations authorized to run formal CMMC assessments against defense contractors. That is what makes the sentence worth reading closely. Axiotrop did not assess MacTech or its Vault-Codex platform, and the letter does not claim otherwise. What it offers is narrower and, for MacTech's purposes, more useful: confirmation from an organization that spends its working life evaluating cybersecurity documentation that the problem MacTech is building toward is one assessors actually encounter, not one MacTech invented to sell a product into.

7 min

READING TIME, NO PAYWALL, NO POP-UPS

◆ WHAT AXIOTROP IS, AND ISN'T, SAYING

Axiotrop confirmed the documentation and evidence problem is "real and relevant" and supports further research into a human-attested, source-traceable approach. It did not assess, name, or endorse Vault-Codex, and the letter is explicit that it creates no procurement commitment, certification decision, or formal partnership.

Where the evidence actually breaks

The letter is specific about the shape of the problem. Research, development, rapid-prototyping, and defense industrial base organizations, in Axiotrop's language, "frequently struggle to prepare complete, internally consistent, and evidence-supported" Risk Management Framework documentation before a formal review. Implementation statements go in thin. Evidence that should support a control narrative doesn't quite line up with it. Inconsistencies sit unresolved because nobody owns reconciling them. The result, per the letter, is "avoidable rework" that eats into assessor and cybersecurity-review time that was never abundant to begin with.

None of what follows in this section is Axiotrop's language - it's MacTech's own account of why the problem lands the way it does. A large enterprise absorbs documentation gaps with a compliance department sized to catch them before an assessor does. A small or mid-sized contractor usually has one person doing that job alongside three others, and the artifacts that are supposed to prove a control is implemented are scattered across a shared drive, a spreadsheet, an email thread, a policy repository, a ticketing system, a consultant's PDF, a screenshot folder, and whatever the last assessment workbook happened to capture. Proving that a written claim is backed by evidence means finding all of it first, and finding it is where the hours go.

Vault-Codex: applying the principle the letter describes

MacTech's SBIR proposal describes a research effort it calls Codex RMF-AIR: an artifact-centric capability that would organize RMF documentation, link proposed findings back to the source material behind them, distinguish a narrative claim from the evidence that actually supports it, and score its own confidence rather than assert certainty. Axiotrop's letter addresses that proposal directly. It does not name or evaluate Vault-Codex, MacTech's broader secure compliance evidence, documentation, and workflow platform - and this article does not claim otherwise.

The connection is one MacTech is drawing, not one Axiotrop drew: the same principles the letter engages with in the SBIR proposal are the ones MacTech is applying through the continued development of Vault-Codex, across CMMC, CUI, RMF, and NIST 800-171 environments generally rather than one research topic specifically. Vault-Codex is designed to help an organization centralize its compliance evidence, associate that evidence with the controls and requirements it's meant to satisfy, track where the documentation gaps sit, and keep a record of who approved what and when. It is being developed to distinguish a written claim from the artifact that backs it up - the exact distinction Axiotrop's letter identifies as the one organizations most often fail to maintain. None of that is a claim that every piece of it is finished, shipped, or independently verified; it's a description of the direction the platform is built in.

Decision support, not automated certification

The letter draws a boundary that matters more than any capability claim: "The proposed approach is appropriately framed as decision support rather than automated authorization or certification." Assessors, system owners, cybersecurity professionals, and authorizing officials keep their existing authority under that framing. Nothing about the research replaces their judgment or their sign-off.

That boundary is the one Vault-Codex is built around. MacTech does not intend for artificial intelligence to stand in for a CMMC assessor, a system owner, or an authorizing official, and any AI-generated observation the platform surfaces - a gap flagged, a mapping suggested, an inconsistency noted - remains subject to review and approval by a qualified person before it becomes anything more than a suggestion. Where the technology is intended to help is upstream of that judgment: organizing artifacts, surfacing candidate evidence, checking for internal consistency, mapping a requirement to the material that might satisfy it, and prioritizing what a reviewer should look at first. Axiotrop's letter puts the underlying requirement plainly: "Preserving source traceability, reviewer accountability, and a clear boundary between AI-generated observations and human-approved determinations is essential for responsible use of AI in RMF, CMMC, CUI, and defense cybersecurity workflows." MacTech's objective is not to automate trust. It is to make the evidence behind cybersecurity decisions easier to organize, review, trace, and defend.

That is also where the letter's discussion of timeliness lands. Axiotrop writes that it "supports MacTech's investigation of this capability and believes the proposed Phase I research addresses a timely cybersecurity-readiness and assessment-efficiency problem." The two halves of that phrase are connected rather than coincidental: poor evidence organization slows a review down, inconsistent records generate follow-up questions that a better-prepared submission wouldn't, and an assessor's or reviewer's time is the scarcest resource in the whole process. A small contractor preparing for a Level 2 assessment or an RMF authorization is rarely short on requirements to meet - see our earlier look at running both programs as one system - it's short on the internal bandwidth to prove, cleanly, that it has already met them.

What the letter supports, and what it doesn't

Axiotrop's letter supports the relevance of the underlying problem, the value of researching a human-attested, source-traceable approach to it, and the idea that a capability like this "could provide value to small and mid-sized organizations by helping them improve evidence quality, identify documentation gaps earlier, prepare for formal review more efficiently, and maintain clearer visibility" between controls, architecture, implementation statements, and evidence. The letter also discloses that Axiotrop and MacTech are discussing a possible advisory role in the Phase I effort - one the letter is careful to note would require its own signed agreement, separate from the letter itself, and would remain subject to independence and conflict-of-interest rules that apply to any C3PAO.

What the letter is not is a wider set of things worth naming plainly, because Axiotrop named them first: not a procurement commitment, not a pricing or exclusivity arrangement, not a certification or assessment decision, not an endorsement of any compliance outcome, and not a representation that the proposed research has already been validated. It is not a completed advisory agreement, and it is not a validation of Vault-Codex as a product - because Vault-Codex is not what the letter was written about. What it is, is an assessor telling a federal agency, on the record, that the problem is real.

Vault-Codex is one part of the broader platform estate MacTech is building for defense contractors to run compliance, quality, and governance work in one place rather than across a dozen disconnected tools - the same pattern underlying MacTech's readiness assessments and its work on CUI enclave scoping. This piece is about the documentation problem specifically, and about a C3PAO's word that MacTech isn't the only one who sees it.

If your organization is losing hours to inconsistent RMF or CMMC documentation, or if you're a cybersecurity professional, assessor, or researcher with a view on what responsible, human-attested AI should look like in this space, MacTech wants to hear it - start a conversation here. Readers who want to follow where Vault-Codex goes from here can watch this space; MacZine will report on it as there's something concrete to report. ◆